Finding the device that keeps locking your account

Article KB0010005 | Owner: Service Desk L1 | Subcategory: Account locked | Applies to: Windows 11 laptops (Dell Latitude 5440/7440, Lenovo ThinkPad T14/X1 Carbon, HP EliteBook 840), macOS laptops (MacBook Pro/Air) when accessing Windows resources via SMB or mapped drives, Mobile devices using Outlook/Exchange ActiveSync, Any Acme-Global joined workstation

Summary

This article helps users and L1 service-desk agents identify why an Acme Global account keeps getting locked out and provides step-by-step guidance to locate and remove stale credentials, unlock the account, and prevent recurrence.

Symptoms

- Login prompt shows "Your account has been locked out because there were too many failed login attempts."
- SSO portal displays "Account is disabled" or "Account locked".
- Repeated lockout notifications every morning or after a specific time interval.
- Error 0xC000006A (STATUS_WRONG_PASSWORD) in Windows Event Viewer under Security log.
- Outlook or mobile mail app continually prompts for credentials despite correct password.

Common causes

- Cached credentials stored in a mobile email app (Outlook, iOS/Android Mail) using an old password.
- Saved passwords in web browsers or credential manager for internal sites.
- Mapped network drives or printers reconnecting with stale credentials.
- Scheduled tasks, services, or service-account passwords that have not been updated after a password change.
- Authentication attempts from a lost or stolen device that still holds the old password.
- Expired temporary access pass or mis-configured MFA method causing repeated failures.

Understanding Account Lockouts

When Acme Global's Active Directory detects five failed logon attempts within a short period, it locks the account for 15 minutes. If the source of the bad password is not removed, the lock will repeat each time the offending credential tries to authenticate. Common sources are mobile mail apps, cached web credentials, mapped drives, or automated scripts that still use the previous password. Identifying and clearing these sources stops the cycle and lets the account stay unlocked after the automatic lockout period expires.

Self-Help: Identify and Clear Stale Credentials

Follow these steps to locate and remove the most common sources of stale credentials on your own workstation or mobile device. Completing the procedure often resolves the lockout without needing to contact the Service Desk.

1. Lock your workstation (Win+L) and sign back in to verify you can log in with your current password. If you are immediately locked out again, proceed to the next step.
2. Open Credential Manager: Start -> Search "Credential Manager" -> Open -> Windows Credentials. Look for entries that reference ACME-Corp, file shares, or internal websites (e.g., sharepoint.acme.example). Select each suspicious entry and choose "Remove".
3. Check mapped drives: Open File Explorer -> This PC. Right-click any drive that shows a red X or prompts for credentials, choose "Disconnect". Re-map the drive using your current password (or leave it disconnected if not needed).
4. Inspect Outlook/Exchange ActiveSync on your phone: Go to Settings -> Accounts -> select your Acme account -> choose "Delete Account" and then re-add it using your current password and MFA approval.
5. Clear saved passwords in your browser: Settings -> Privacy & Security -> Passwords -> Remove any entries for *.acme.example domains.
6. After completing the above, lock and unlock your workstation once more. If you remain logged in without a lockout notice for at least 15 minutes, the issue is likely resolved.

Service-Desk Procedure: Diagnose and Resolve Account Lockouts

Agents should follow this structured approach when a user reports repeated lockouts. The goal is to confirm the lock state, locate the source of bad passwords, unlock the account, and document findings for prevention.

1. Verify the account status in Active Directory Users and Computers (ADUC): locate the user account, check if the lockout-time attribute is set (indicating a current lock) or if lockout-time is zero (unlocked). Note the lockout time and the badPwdCount value.
2. If the account is locked, right-click the account -> Properties -> Account tab -> uncheck "Account is locked out" and click OK. This clears the immediate lock.
3. Enable Netwrix/Azure AD sign-in logs or use Event Viewer on a domain controller to filter for Event ID 4740 (account locked) and 4625 (failed logon) for the user. Identify the client IP address or workstation name associated with the failures.
4. Ask the user to check the identified workstation or device for stale credentials using the self-help steps above (Credential Manager, mapped drives, mobile mail, browser passwords).
5. If the source is a mapped drive or scheduled task, guide the user to update or remove the credential, then re-test authentication.
6. After the source is removed, monitor the account for 15 minutes. If no further lockout events appear, close the ticket and advise the user to enable credential-manager alerts or schedule a quarterly password-review.
7. Document the root cause (e.g., "Outlook Android app cached old password") and any user-specific actions taken in the ticket notes.

Verification: Confirm Account Is Unlocked and No Further Lockouts

Once the suspected stale credential has been cleared, verify that the account remains unlocked and that the user can access all expected resources without prompting for a password.

1. Have the user log off and log back in on their primary workstation. Confirm they reach the desktop without a lockout message.
2. Attempt to access a typical internal resource (e.g., \\files.acme.example\share or Outlook Web Access) and ensure no credential prompts appear.
3. Check the domain controller security log for the user: there should be no new Event ID 4740 entries after the time of remediation.
4. If the user uses a mobile device, send a test email and verify it sends/receives without re-prompting for credentials.
5. If any of these checks fail, repeat the self-help steps or escalate as described below.

Prevention: Avoid Future Lockouts

Encourage users to adopt habits that reduce the chance of leaving stale credentials behind after a password change.

1. When you change your Acme password, immediately update it in Outlook/Exchange ActiveSync on all mobile devices.
2. After a password change, open Credential Manager and delete any entries that you know you will no longer need (old service accounts, test shares).
3. Disconnect and re-map any network drives that use explicit credentials; prefer to rely on single sign-on where possible.
4. Periodically review saved passwords in your browser and remove entries for internal Acme sites.
5. If you use a service account or scheduled task, maintain a password-change calendar and update the credentials in the task scheduler or service console promptly.

When to escalate

If the account continues to lock out after completing the self-help and service-desk steps, or if the lockout events originate from unfamiliar IP addresses or devices, escalate to the Identity & Access Management (IAM) team. Provide the following details: username, timestamps of the last three lockout events (Event ID 4740), source IP addresses or hostnames from the domain controller security logs, and a summary of credential-checking steps already performed. IAM will investigate possible credential compromise, review conditional access policies, and issue a Temporary Access Pass if needed.

Keywords: account locked out, lockout, failed login, credential manager, cached password, mobile mail, Outlook, mapped drive, scheduled task, SSO disabled, Event ID 4740, bad password, Unlock account, Active Directory lock, Password reset